The Arrangement

By Neil Simon

Suggested Roles: ***Actor 1:*** *Writer, Father*
Actor 2: *Boy, Girl*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

As the lights come up, we are on a wharf. The WRITER enters and addresses the audience.

WRITER: This one goes back a good many years ago to my youth . . . I was nineteen years old, to be exact . . . And in the ways of love, I was not only unschooled -- I hadn't even been in the classroom. I was so innocent and shy that I actually thought that, since the beginning of time, no woman had ***ever*** been completely unclothed. As for connubial bliss, I dared not think of it. And as for impregnation, I chose to believe it was caused by the husband giving the wife a most ardent handshake before retiring . . . and let it go at that. But my father was a wonderful man -- quite liberal in his thinking. And on the occasion of my nineteenth birthday, he decided to introduce me to the mysteries of love. He was, however, a frugal man, and decided to escort me himself, to see, in the matter of bargaining, that I would not be taken advantage of . . . Picture me, if you will, as my own dear father . . .

FATHER: *(He calls out to the side)* Antosha! Antosha! Where are you? . . . Don't stand there in the dark shaking like a puppy dog. Come here. We have some adolescence to get over with

INTRODUCTION

The Arrangement from The Good Doctor by Neil Simon

(Young Anton appears, 19-years-old, as nervous as a puppy. He frets with his hat in his hand)

BOY: I'm not well, Father. I'm sick.

FATHER: Sick? Sick? What's wrong with you?

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BOY: I haven't thought of it yet. Give me a few minutes.

FATHER: Fear. That's all it is. Pubescent fear. I was the same way when I was your age.

BOY: I never knew you were my age . . . I always thought of you as older.

FATHER: How old do you think I was when I was with my first woman?

BOY: You were with a woman, Father?

FATHER: Certainly, I was with a woman. All men who become fathers have been with a woman at some point in their life.

BOY: The same woman?

FATHER: *(Yells)* Certainly not the same woman! My God, don't you ever discuss these matters with your young friends?

BOY: Oh, yes. All the time. But we get too excited to listen.

FATHER: It's a man's obligation to enter a marriage experienced in the ways of love . . . otherwise valuable years are wasted in endless groping.

BOY: I don't mind wasting a few years groping, Father.

FATHER: It's all in the process of becoming a man, Antosha. First you learned to walk, then you learned to talk-and now it's time to learn this.

BOY: Are you sure, Father? I'm really not walking and talking that well.

FATHER: *(Irritated)* Antosha, we can't afford to delay any longer. I don't want you becoming an old man waiting to become a young man . . . Now, are you going to walk in there and have your first experience with a woman or do I have to punish you?

BOY: Father . . . I don't think we're going to find any women of high moral character around here.

FATHER: We're not looking for *high-moraled* women. There are too damn many high-moraled women in the world as it is . . . That's why so many high-moraled men have to come down to places like this . . . Now, let's get on with this business.

BOY: Can I hold your hand, Father?

FATHER: ***Certainly not!*** You can't go in there to become a man holding your father's hand . . . Antosha, we don't have all day. Your mother is expecting us home by nine o'clock . . . Now

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we have exactly an hour and ten minutes for you to mature.

BOY: You mean you told mother where we were going?

FATHER: Do you think I'm so insensitive? I told her we were going out for a walk just to get some night air.

BOY: Won't she become suspicious when she notices that I've come home all grown up?

FATHER: It doesn't *show,* Anton. You don't get spots like measles . . . You may possibly have a small smile on your face, that's all . . . Now, come along.

BOY: Father, aren't there other ways to become a man? I mean, couldn't I grow a moustache?

FATHER: Antosha, tell me the truth, if you'd rather not go through with it, I'll take you home.

BOY: *(Nods)* Take me home!

FATHER: ***Wait till I ask the question!*** Would you rather not go through with it? I'll take you home . . . ?

BOY: Take me home!

FATHER: I see! Very well, let's go home . . . You can get in your tub and play with your sailboats until you're ready.

BOY: Will you be angry with me?

FATHER: No.

BOY: Will you be disappointed with me?

FATHER: No.

BOY: Will you be proud of me?

FATHER: No.

BOY: All right, I'll do it.

FATHER: Good boy, Antosha.

BOY: If I like it, can we do it again?

FATHER: No! I didn't bring you down here with the intention of leaving you here . . . By God, it's a difficult business being a liberal father. *(The GIRL enters. She has flaming red hair and a cigarette in her mouth)*

GIRL: 'Evening, gentlemen!

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BOY: Oh, God.

FATHER: Steady, boy, steady.

BOY: Is she . . . Is she one of the teachers?

FATHER: She looks like the principal to me. We're in luck, son. She's a charming-looking girl. I'll go over and attend to your tuition . . .

BOY: Father . . . couldn't I take a correspondence course?

FATHER: No! Stand there! Don't move! I'll be right backand don't twiddle with your hat. This is not hat-twiddling business *(He goes over to the GIRL)* Good evening, Madame. A lovely April night, wouldn't you say?

GIRL: Is it April already? . . . I don't get out very much.

FATHER: No, I can well understand that . . . It's, er . . . it's been a long time since I've been involved in such matters, but I would like to discuss with you a subject of some delicacy-

GIRL: Thirty rubles!

FATHER: SO much for the delicacy . . . Thirty rubles, you say. Well, speaking for myself, I would say thirty rubles was quite fair. But it's not for me. It's for my young, inexperienced son. That's him! The one with the knees buckling.

GIRL: It's still thirty rubles, sir. We don't have children's prices down here.

FATHER: No, of course not. But thirty rubles does seem a bit high for a boy of nineteen . . . Would you consider fifteen rubles?

GIRL: For fifteen rubles I read *Peter Rabbitt.* Sir, a Norwegian ship is due in here tonight and I have to go in and put on my blond wig.

FATHER: Wait! There *is* an extenuating circumstance. .. It's the boy's birthday, and I wanted to give him a nice gift . . . What do you say?

GIRL: How about an umbrella?

FATHER: See here. In my day, thirty years ago, I shared the pleasures of the most delightful girl on this street-Ilka the Milkmaid, she was called-and she cost me a mere ten rubles.

GIRL: Well, she's still here. If you want her, she's down to six rubles now.

FATHER: Certainly not, good heavens . . .

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BOY: Father? Oh, Father?

FATHER: Yes?

BOY: Am I ready yet?

FATHER: In a minute. I'm still shopping . . . *(To the GIRL)* He's really a lovely boy - fragile and sweet. Tells the most delightful stories I'm sure you'll find him most entertaining.

GIRL: Haven't you got it the wrong way around, sir?

BOY: Father, I'm getting chilly.

FATHER: *(To his son)* Well, run around, jump up and down. Be patient. You've waited nineteen years, it's just another few minutes . . . *(To the GIRL)* Twenty rubles not a kopeck more. There's just so much I'm willing to spend on education. Please, it's for my boy.

GIRL: *(Looks at him, then smiles)* Settled! You're a good and loving father, sir, and I respect you for it. If I had a father like you, I would never have ended up here on the streets bargaining with fathers like you.

FATHER: *(Puzzled)* I'm sure there's a moral in there somewhere, I just don't see it yet . . . Settled, for twenty rubles. *(Gives her the money)* Oh, there's just one other request I have . . At the conclusion of the evening's festivities, I would appreciate it greatly if you would just say, "Happy Birthday from Poppa."

GIRL: *(Nods)* "Happy Birthday from Poppa" . . . Would you like any candles, sir?

FATHER: That's not necessary. Just be gentle and kind to him. Gentleness, that's all I ask . . . *(Wipes his eye)* Good heavens, a tear . . . What a thing to cry over.

GIRL: I'll wait upstairs. Two flights up, second door on the left. I'll be gentle, sir.

FATHER: Thank you. The girls nowadays seem to be so much more understanding.

GIRL: May I say, it's men like you who make me proud to serve in my profession. *(She kisses his hand and goes)*

FATHER: What a wonderful nurse she would have made . . . Antosha, school's in. *(He turns, crosses to the BOY)* Settled, my boy. Twenty rubles. You have to know how to bargain with these people. Well, off you go. Two flights up, second door on the left. I'll wait out here. Don't rush. *(The BOY starts, then stops)*

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BOY: Father, do I say anything to her?

FATHER: Like what?

BOY: Like "Hello"?

FATHER: "Hello" would be nice . . . "Goodbye" would be good too. Go on, she's waiting.

BOY: Are there any "instructions" you want to give me?

FATHER: That's what I'm paying ***her*** good money for. The questions you ask . . . Go on, boy-before I have to pay her overtime.

BOY: *Yes,* Father . . . I'm going, I'm going . . . *(He stops)*

FATHER: What is it now?

BOY: It's funny, but when I come down those stairs and out into the street . . . I won't be your little Antosha any more . . . I'll be Anton the Man. Thank you, Father. Well, goodbye. *(He gets to the door)*

FATHER: Wait! *(Anton stops)* Wait-Antosha!

BOY: What is it, Father?

FATHER: I was just thinking . . . Wouldn't you rather have a nice umbrella? There's plenty of time next year to become a man. Plenty of time next year . . .

BOY: If you wish, Pappa. Yes, Pappa.

(The FATHER puts his arm around his son's shoulder, and they tum and walk off into the night. Music plays as the stage dims out)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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